



HEALING TOUCH:
Textiles being dyed

GIREESH G V

AYURVEDIC TEXTILES

Thiruvananthapuram | KERALA



Thiruvananthapuram

Herbal essence

Ayurvedic medicines and handloom fabrics. Weave them together and it may just be what a toxin-weary consumer would want to wear.

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

The next time you wear your favourite shade of brown, it might just help you breathe free. No, we're not talking colour therapy. The dye might be derived from the seeds of *kadakka* (*terminalia chebula*), an ayurvedic plant known for its anti-asthmatic properties. If red is your colour, you do not need to look beyond the flowers and bark of the anti-cancerous *pathimukham* (*caesalpinia saphans*) and for blue, there's *neela amari* (*indigofera tinctora*), ideal for epilepsy and skin diseases.

The traditional weaving family of Kuzhivilas in Balaramapuram, on the outskirts of Thiruvananthapuram, used to provide ayurvedic medicines and handloom fab-

rics to the Travancore royalty. At times the family would mix its two core competencies and supply 'ayurvedic garments' to the royals. The tradition dwindled as modern textile mills took over. Now, with God's Own Country finding its place in the world tourism map, and ayurveda and handloom becoming buzzwords in the culture of eco-friendly cool, there is new hope for the art of medicinal dyeing. Kuzhivila's new generation has revived the tradition by launching Ayurvastra.

"Our dyes are made from organic herbs, seeds and fruits that prevent and even cure many diseases," says Kuzhivila Vijayan, 37, who heads the

Ayurvastra Handloom Weavers Development Society. Ayurvastra's herbal-dyed bed-sheets, beddings and pillows have been clinically tested by the Government Ayurveda College in Thiruvananthapuram, which has confirmed their effect on rheumatic patients. The society

supplies medicinal sheets and pillows to a number of hospitals in and outside the state, and also exports ayurvedic-dyed

yoga mats to the US. "Developed countries, which are rejecting Chinese textiles for health reasons, are major markets," says Rajan, a Kuzhivila. For a world alarmed by the hazards of toxic dyes, Ayurvastra is a stitch in time.

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CRORE RUPEES IS
THE ESTIMATED VALUE
OF INDIA'S CURRENT
AYURVEDIC
PRODUCTION